E2 Speaking and Listening Exam Prep - Lesson Plan and Answers - Version 1

Oct 7, 2026 · @Atin

Exam at a glance

Learners take the exam in pairs. It has four tasks and about 25 minutes of guide time. This follows ESB Entry 2 sample Set O; check your live ESB set for any changes.

Task	What learners do	Guide time	What to work on (assessors' report)
1 Exchange of personal information	Ask each other questions, then answer the assessor's questions on area, work or study, plans and events	5 min	Answers sound memorised; question forms get weaker later in the exam
2 Unprepared talk	Talk for 2 minutes on a topic from the assessor, usually a past event. Partner listens and asks two questions	6 min	Use the one-minute preparation time; practise the long turn
3 Describing pictures	Describe two pictures, compare them and give an opinion, for about 2 minutes	4 min	Comparatives; saying what is the same and what is different
4 Listening and discussion	Hear two short texts, each played twice. A yes/no gist question, then a detail question. Then a 3-minute discussion on the topic	10 min	Listening for gist

The last column is from the ESB Assessors' Report 2023-24. The report names note-making in the thinking minute at Entry 1; confirm with ESB that notes are allowed at Entry 2 before you promise it to learners.

Lesson overview

One 120-minute lesson that walks learners through all four tasks, with most practice time on the points assessors flag. If you need a 10-minute break, take it after Stage 3 and cut Stage 6 to a two-minute recap.

By the end, learners can:

- say what happens in each of the four tasks
- ask at least six correct personal questions and one follow-up question
- give a talk of one to two minutes about a past event from key-word notes
- compare two pictures using comparatives and say which they prefer
- answer a yes/no gist question and a detail question on a short spoken text

You need: the Student Handouts document (one copy each), two pairs of photos to project, a timer, scrap paper. No audio is needed: you read the listening texts aloud.

Time	Stage	Exam task	Handout
0-10	1 What happens in the exam?	All	1
10-35	2 Asking and answering questions	Task 1	2
35-60	3 The two-minute talk	Task 2	3
60-85	4 Describe and compare pictures	Task 3	4
85-110	5 Listening and discussion	Task 4	5
110-120	6 Mini mock and self-check	All	6

Stage-by-stage plan

Stage 1: What happens in the exam? (0-10)

Learners leave this stage able to say what each task is.

1. Board: **ESB Speaking and Listening exam**. Ask: “Who is in the room?” (you, a partner, the assessor). “How long is it?” (about 25 minutes). “Do you write?” (no).
2. Handout 1, Part A. Learners match the four tasks to what you do. Three minutes alone, then compare with a partner.
3. Part B, true or false. Check as a class and correct the false sentences aloud.
4. Say: “The assessor wants to hear you talk. Do not learn a speech. Listen to the question and answer it.”

Stage 2: Asking and answering questions - Task 1 (10-35)

The target is correct question forms in three times, plus real follow-up questions instead of a memorised list.

1. **Board (2 min).** Write NOW / LAST WEEK / NEXT YEAR. Elicit one question under each: What do you do…? What did you do…? What are you going to do…? Underline do / did / are.
2. **Handout 2, Part A (8 min).** Learners build eight questions from prompts. Check on the board. Drill chorally, then individually: falling voice at the end of Wh- questions, and “did you” said as one sound.
3. **Follow-up questions (5 min).** Model with a confident learner. You: “Where do you live?” Learner: “In Hackney.” You: “Do you like it? … Why?” Point to Part B on the handout: Why? / Do you like it? / How often? / Who with? / What is it like?
4. **Question chain (8 min).** Pairs. A asks a question from Part A. B answers with a full sentence and one more thing. A must then ask one follow-up question that is not on the page. Swap. Change partners after four minutes.
5. **Feedback (2 min).** Board three question errors you heard, without names. Learners correct them.

Board the rule: **Answer + one more thing.** “I live in Hackney. It is busy but I like it.”

Accept “I live in a hotel in…” and “I’d like to be a…” as full answers. Do not push for details on family, country or the journey here.

Stage 3: The two-minute talk - Task 2 (35-60)

The target is a talk about a past event, built from key-word notes made in one minute.

1. **Listen (3 min).** Handouts face down. Read Amina’s talk aloud (the full text is in the answers below). Ask: “Did she have a good day?” (Yes.) “Where did she go?” (Victoria Park.)
2. **Handout 3, Part A (7 min).** Learners complete the talk with past simple verbs. Check. Drill went, took, saw, made, bought, felt.
3. **Notes, not sentences (3 min).** Show Amina’s notes in Part B. Ask: “Are these sentences?” (No, words.) “How long to write them?” (One minute.)
4. **Thinking minute (2 min).** Each learner picks a topic from Part C. Time one minute of silent note-making in the box. Stop them at 60 seconds.
5. **Talk, round 1 (4 min).** Pairs. A talks for 90 seconds. B listens, then asks two questions using the starters in Part D. Swap.
6. **Talk, round 2 (4 min).** New partner, same topic, full two minutes each if time allows, otherwise 90 seconds. The second attempt is always longer and more accurate; tell them so.
7. **Feedback (2 min).** Board two good sentences you heard and two past-tense errors to correct.

If a speaker stops early, the partner says “And then?” or “Tell me more.” Teach both phrases before round 1.

Stage 4: Describe and compare pictures - Task 3 (60-85)

The target is three steps every time: describe, compare, opinion. Comparatives are the weak point at this level.

Project two photos side by side. Suggested pairs:

- Pair A: a street market (Ridley Road Market) and a supermarket
- Pair B: a park (London Fields) and a busy shopping street
- Pair C (spare): a bus and a bicycle

1. **Vocabulary (5 min).** Show Pair A. Elicit what learners can see into two board columns, one per picture. Model: “There is a… / There are some… / The people are buying…”
2. **Handout 4, Parts A and B (8 min).** Learners complete the comparatives table, then the five sentences. Check. Board the rule: short word + er (cheaper); y changes to ier (busier); long word = more (more expensive); good becomes better.
3. **Model the three steps (3 min).** Speak for one minute about Pair A yourself. Learners tick the steps in Part C as they hear them: 1 Describe. 2 Compare (“Both pictures show… but…”). 3 Opinion (“I prefer… because…”).
4. **Pairs (7 min).** Show Pair B. A speaks for two minutes using the three steps. B ticks the steps, then asks: “Which do you prefer? Why?” Swap, using Pair A or Pair C.
5. **Feedback (2 min).** Correct one comparative error on the board. Praise anyone who said what is the same as well as what is different.

Stage 5: Listening and discussion - Task 4 (85-110)

The target is hearing the topic first, then one detail. You read both texts aloud.

1. **Explain (2 min).** “You hear two texts. You hear each one two times. First time: I ask yes or no. Second time: I ask a question first, then you listen for the answer. In the exam you say the answer. Today you write it, so everyone can practise.”
2. **Text 1 (8 min).** Read at natural speed. Turn your head or change voice for the two speakers. Learners tick yes or no for questions 1 and 2 on Handout 5. Read questions 3 and 4 aloud, then read the text again. Learners write short answers. Check.
3. **Text 2 (7 min).** Same steps.
4. **Discussion (6 min).** Groups of three: two learners and one “assessor” who asks the questions in Part C. Three minutes, then change the assessor. Point to the useful phrases first.
5. **Feedback (2 min).** Ask two groups what their partner said.

Text 1 - at the library

Librarian: Good afternoon. Can I help you?

Customer: Yes, please. I want to join the library. How much does it cost?

Librarian: It’s free. Do you have a letter with your name and address?

Customer: No, I left it at home. I only have my college card.

Librarian: That’s OK. Bring the letter tomorrow and I can make your card then.

Customer: Thank you. What time do you close tomorrow?

Librarian: We close at six o’clock. The computers are on the first floor, next to the children’s books.

Customer: Great. See you tomorrow.

Text 2 - the community garden

Good morning everyone. I want to tell you about the new community garden near the college. It opens on Monday. First, there is a vegetable garden. You can grow tomatoes and potatoes there, and you can take them home. Next to the gate there is a small kitchen where you can make tea and coffee. Every Wednesday afternoon there is a free gardening class. It starts at two o’clock and you don’t need to book. Please wear old shoes because the garden is often wet. I hope you enjoy the garden and come often.

Stage 6: Mini mock and self-check (110-120)

Learners run a six-minute version of the exam, then mark their own confidence.

1. **Mini mock (6 min).** Pairs, using the card on Handout 6. One minute each asking questions. One minute each talking about yesterday. One minute each on a picture pair left on the board. Time it aloud.
2. **Self-check (3 min).** Learners tick the “I can” list on Handout 6. Collect a show of hands for the hardest task; that is your next lesson.
3. **Homework (1 min).** Choose one topic from Handout 3, Part C. Make notes for one minute. Talk for two minutes with a phone timer.

Answers

Handout 1

Part A: 1 c, 2 d, 3 a, 4 b.

Part B: 1 False (with a partner). 2 True. 3 False (two minutes). 4 True. 5 True. 6 False (you say your answers).

Handout 2

1. Where do you live?
2. Who do you live with?
3. What do you do at the weekend?
4. Are there any shops near your home?
5. What did you do last weekend?
6. What did you eat yesterday?
7. What are you going to do next year?
8. What job would you like in the future?

Handout 3

Part A: 1 went, 2 took, 3 was, 4 walked, 5 saw, 6 had, 7 made, 8 bought, 9 rained, 10 went, 11 felt.

Full text to read aloud:

> Last Saturday I went to Victoria Park with my friend Sara. We took the bus because it was a long walk. First, we walked around the lake and we saw a lot of ducks. Then we had a picnic. I made rice and chicken, and Sara bought some fruit from the market. In the afternoon it rained, so we went home early. I felt tired but happy. It was a good day.

Handout 4

Part A: bigger, cheaper, quieter, busier, noisier, more expensive, more crowded, better.

Part B: 1 busier, 2 quieter, 3 cheaper, 4 more expensive, 5 better.

Handout 5

Text	Question	Answer
1 Library	1 Is this about buying books?	No
1 Library	2 Is this about joining a library?	Yes
1 Library	3 How much does it cost to join the library?	It is free / nothing
1 Library	4 What time does the library close tomorrow?	(At) six o’clock
2 Garden	1 Is this about a new garden?	Yes
2 Garden	2 Is this about a cooking class?	No
2 Garden	3 When does the garden open?	(On) Monday
2 Garden	4 What time does the gardening class start?	(At) two o’clock